

Piper J3 Cub

The J3 Cub was the first and most famous aircraft to be produced by Piper. Developed from the Depression-era Taylor E-2 Cub, an ultralight airplane that used the wings from a glider, the J3 proved such a success that 60 percent of US light aircraft were Cubs by 1941. After World War II, J3 production topped 20,000. Piper continued the line with the PA-18 Super Cub until 1994, and J3 replicas are still being marketed today.

WHEN DESIGNER C. GILBERT TAYLOR and business partner William Piper set out to build the E2 Cub in 1930, they aimed to create the cheapest and most economical two-seat aircraft possible. Combining a new, fabric-covered welded-steel tube fuselage with the simple, strut-braced wing from Taylor's Model D glider, they produced an open-cockpit parasol monoplane that flew well on just 40 hp.

By blending Taylor's winter flying cockpit "enclosure" with a raised fuselage decking and rounding the tips of the flying surfaces, the E2 was transformed into the much more civilized and far prettier J2. The beefed-up and further refined J3, which appeared as the company name was changed to Piper, was quickly fitted with a more powerful 65 hp Continental, making it the definitive Cub.

While the J3 line gave way to the heavier, more powerful PA-18 Super Cub in late 1949, many owners preferred the sweet handling and economy of the earlier model—so much so that improved versions are popular today as Light Sport Aircraft.



FRONT VIEW



REAR VIEW

